

Intelligence Capability Kit — Full Tiers

Version 1.0 — August 2026

Companions: *Intelligence Capability Tree* · *OSINT Capability Ladder*

Layer: **volatile** (gear, apps, vendors, prices). Re-check quarterly.

Footings: **A** open/lawful purchase · **B** written authorization · **C** regulated intercept · **D** human contact

Default in this kit: **Footing A + no-touch**. Footing B items are marked. C/D are not stocked here.

0. How to read this

Each tier is a **complete kit snapshot**: what you should physically have, what runs on the phone, what runs on the research machine, which accounts exist, and what the desk/network looks like.

Inheritance rule: Tier *N* includes everything in Tier *N*–1 unless replaced. Lists below are additive.

Branch rule: The core kit is cross-branch (enablers + OSINT spine). Branch add-ons appear after the core tiers. Do not buy SIGINT/HUMINT kits from a blog post — those need their own counsel-backed docs.

Cost bands are indicative US retail as of Aug 2026 mindset; confirm on vendor pages before committing.

Tier 0 — Ad hoc

Capability: Answer one question once, by hand.

Ceiling: Not repeatable, not preserved, not defensible.

Move up when: Same shape of question twice, or the answer might matter to someone else.

Devices

Item	Spec / note
Whatever phone and laptop you already own	Personal machine — acceptable only at Tier 0
No dedicated research hardware	—

Phone (personal — accept the risk)

App / function	Purpose
Stock browser or Firefox Focus	Quick lookups
Maps (Google Maps / Apple Maps / Organic Maps)	Rough geo
Camera + Files	Screenshots you will probably lose
Authenticator you already use	Only if you must; prefer not mixing

Do not: install a pile of “OSINT apps,” create research accounts on your daily phone, or SMS-verify anything investigative to your real number.

Laptop / desktop

App	Purpose
Browser	Search, whois web UIs, archive.today, Wayback
Notes app or plain text	Scratch — not a case system
PDF reader	Reports you found

Accounts

- Personal Google/Microsoft/Apple (contamination accepted at Tier 0 only)
- Optional: free Shodan/Censys/Netlas account for curiosity queries

Setup look

One browser window, one notes file, no VPN discipline, no evidence hash. Fine for curiosity. Useless for anything you'd stake a claim on.

Explicitly not in Tier 0

Dedicated machine, Hunchly, Maltego Graph workflows, burner SIM, VPS, proxies, case vault, active scanners against third parties.

Tier 1 — Foundation

Capability: Structured, repeatable, compartmented investigation on a single research machine. Every major selector type has a starting playbook.

Cost: roughly \$0–100/mo + one-time hardware.

Ceiling: Manual; weak persistence between cases; thin chain of custody.

Move up when: Someone asks “how do you know that?” and you lack a timestamped answer.

Devices

Item	Spec / note
Dedicated research laptop or desktop	Not your personal daily driver. Full-disk encryption on (BitLocker / FileVault / LUKS).
RAM	32 GB minimum if you run VMs seriously; 64 GB comfortable
Storage	Fast NVMe; room for VM snapshots (1 TB+ realistic)
Optional: cheap second USB NIC or travel router	Beginnings of traffic separation
Optional: hardware security key	YubiKey-class for research account MFA

Phone kit (research — physically separate if you can)

Prefer a **dedicated cheap Android** (GrapheneOS on Pixel if you can swing it; stock Android in a work profile if not) over loading research onto your daily phone.

App / function	Purpose	Notes
Firefox + uBlock Origin	Compartmented browsing	Separate profile; no Google login
Organic Maps or OsmAnd	Offline/map work without wrapping every pin in a Google account	
Signal (research identity only)	Rare; only if a workflow truly needs it	Never link to personal contacts
2FAS / Aegis (or similar FOSS TOTP)	MFA for research accounts	Not your personal Authy backup
Simple Gallery / Files	Hold captures offline	Export to encrypted vault ASAP
VPN client (Mullvad / IVPN / Proton — pick one paid)	Research egress	Always on for research phone
SMS: burner SIM or app number (TextNow / Hushed / physical prepaid)	Verification	Never your real number or iMessage
Optional: Camo/secondary cam unused	Do not give biometrics to research accounts	FaceID/TouchID off for research IDs

Phone OPSEC rules at Tier 1 - No personal Apple/Google ID on the research phone

- No contacts sync, no fingerprint/face enrolled for research apps
- No payment cards that touch your real identity
- Screenshots are not evidence yet — they become evidence when hashed/stored on the research machine

Research machine — OS and environment

Item	Purpose
Host OS with FDE	Debian/Ubuntu/Fedora/macOS/Windows hardened baseline
Trace Labs OSINT VM (current default bundle) or roll-your-own Debian	Investigation environment
Optional: Tsurugi or CSI Linux	Heavier analysis / forensics-oriented
VirtualBox / VMware / KVM / UTM	Snapshot discipline
Firefox Multi-Account Containers or separate Chromium/Brave profiles	Browser compartmentation
Host firewall; research VM behind VPN/gateway — not naked home IP	Attribution basics

Dead — do not follow guides that recommend: Buscador (discontinued). Treat the rest of that guide as stale.

Core software (Tier 1 spine — Footing A)

Category	Have these
Notes / case scratch	Obsidian (or Logseq) — one vault per case or strict folder hygiene
Archive	Browser bookmarks to Wayback , archive.today ; local save-as when needed
Infra recon (passive-first)	subfinder , httpx , theHarvester , Amass or Sublist3r, crt.sh usage, WHOIS/RDAP, dig/drill
Still useful	Nmap — know when it is active; do not point it at third parties without Footing B
Metadata	ExifTool
Geo / verify	Browser + Bellingcat Online Investigation Toolkit index; InVID / WeVerify browser plugin
On-chain (light)	Browser: Breadcrumbs , MetaSleuth , Arkham free, standard explorers
Link analysis (light)	Maltego CE and/or SpiderFoot (self-hosted or local)
Password manager	Bitwarden / KeePassXC — research vault separate from personal
VPN	Same provider as phone; kill switch on

ProjectDiscovery note: `subfinder` / passive use = kit OK. `naabu` / `nuclei` **against third parties = Footing B only**. Keep them installed if you do authorized ASM; do not treat them as default OSINT.

Accounts to open at Tier 1

Account	Why
Free tiers: Shodan, Censys, ZoomEye, FOFA, Netlas, Criminal IP	Each covers gaps; free is demo-grade
Have I Been Pwned (or equivalent API)	Exposure checks — query, don't use passwords
GitHub (research)	Clone tools; not your personal identity if avoidable
Dedicated research email (Proton / Tuta / separate Google under research OPSEC)	Sock/account recovery without personal crossover
archive.today / similar — no login required	Cite-after-archive habit

If you spend one dollar on scan data: Shodan's one-time membership is still usually the best first paid chip (confirm live pricing).

Network / desk look at Tier 1

```
[Home ISP]
├── optional travel router / guest VLAN
│   └── Research laptop (FDE)
│       ├── Host VPN
│       └── TL OSINT VM (snapshots)
│           ├── Firefox containers (case A / case B / sock)
│           └── Tool CLI + Obsidian vault (encrypted disk)
[Research phone + burner SIM] — VPN — never shares Apple/Google ID with daily phone
[Daily phone / daily laptop] — air gap in habits; no research logins
```

Playbook stubs you must write (even if short)

Domain · IP · email · username · phone · image · wallet — one page each: first five moves, stop rule, what to archive.

Explicitly not required yet

Hunchly paid, second attribution machine, residential proxy pool, always-on collectors, MISP/OpenCTI, commercial SOCMINT suites, team QA.

Tier 2 — Defensible practitioner

Capability: Evidence discipline. Timestamped hashed capture; case system; source log; confidence-graded reports; graphs bigger than working memory.

Cost: roughly \$200–1,000/mo all-in for a serious solo.

Ceiling: Point-in-time; weak “when did this change?”; each case still starts cold.

Move up when: The product shifts from investigation to monitoring.

Devices (add)

Item	Spec / note
Second physical machine (or strictly isolated mini-PC)	Attribution-sensitive browsing; VM isolation ≠ fingerprint isolation
Encrypted external SSD	Evidence retention with a <i>written</i> retention period
Dedicated burner phone with physical prepaid SIM	Prefer physical over app-numbers for longevity
Hardware keys (2+)	Research admin + evidence vault MFA
Optional: Faraday pouch	Phone storage when OPSEC moments matter

Phone kit (add)

App / function	Purpose
Separate research APKs only via F-Droid / Aurora where sane	Reduce Play Services tether
Secure camera app that does not auto-cloud	Field photos of documents/scenes you are allowed to shoot
Offline password vault client	Bitwarden/KeePass sync to research vault only
Optional: session-isolation browsers (Falcon / Mulvad browser if available on your platform)	Extra compartment

Still **no** personal banking apps, personal social apps, or real-name SIM on this device.

Research software (add — highest leverage first)

Item	Why it earns Tier 2
Hunchly (or equivalent capture-as-you-browse with hashing)	Single highest-leverage purchase — browsing becomes evidence
Maltego paid transforms if CE is choking you	Interactive link analysis at real volume
SpiderFoot automation sweeps	Breadth-first collection into a DB
reNgin or Faraday	Consolidation UI / aggregation
Local WARC tooling (wget/wget2 WARC, browser export discipline)	Archive you control
Report template	Confidence grading (Admiralty or equivalent) baked in
Optional: Multilogin / GoLogin / AdsPower	Fingerprint-isolated browser profiles for research identities — still prefer logged-out; no engagement

Sock-puppet / research-identity stack (minimum viable — all required together)

Only for identities you need; default remains logged-out Footing A.

1. Dedicated browser profile or antideetect profile
2. Dedicated VPN **or** residential proxy egress (different geo if the legend needs it)
3. Dedicated email
4. Dedicated phone number
5. Distinct fingerprint (UA, resolution, TZ, language)
6. No biometric / payment crossover
7. **Age the account** before it matters — fresh accounts burn fast

Legal tension: fake accounts + accepted ToS sank hiQ even when CFAA scraping held. Prefer logged-out. If you must log in, treat it as regulated tradecraft, not a default toggle.

Accounts / data (add)

Spend	Role
Shodan membership / Monitor if you need alerting lite	Scan data that isn't demo-grade
Censys starter if cert-heavy workflows dominate	Precision over bulk
Netlas cheap paid if budget is tight	Fresh scan data
VirusTotal / urlscan.io API keys as needed	File/URL pivots
Sanctions / company-data credits where your CORPINT lane needs them	Jurisdiction-dependent

Evidence & case look at Tier 2

```
CaseID/  
  00_question_and_done.md      # stop rule  
  01_source_log.csv            # URL, UTC time, hash, tool, note  
  02_entities/                 # one note per entity  
  03_captures/                 # Hunchly export + WARC + screenshots  
  04_graphs/                   # Maltego / exports  
  05_report.md                 # graded confidence  
Evidence SSD ← hashed exports; retention clock started
```

Network / desk look at Tier 2

```
[ISP] → router with guest/research VLAN  
    ┌ Research primary (tools, Obsidian, Hunchly, VMs)  
    ┌ Attribution box (browser-only, separate fingerprint world)  
    ┌ Evidence SSD (plugged in only when sealing)  
    └ Research phone + prepaid SIM  
Proxies/VPN egress documented per case in source log  
Daily life devices never join the research VLAN
```

Explicitly not required yet

Always-on collectors, multi-VPS fleet, TIP (MISP/OpenCTI), commercial SOCMINT platform seats, second analyst review as a role.

Tier 3 — Continuous collection

Capability: Standing pipelines; owned collection infrastructure; persistent datastore with history; alerting on change. Longitudinal archive ≠ investigation service.

Cost: roughly \$1,000–10,000/mo — increasingly infra, not licenses.

Ceiling: Solo breaks. Pipelines need care whether or not a client is active. Gaps cannot be backfilled.

Move up when: Maintenance > ~1 day/week, or you-as-SPOF is unacceptable.

Devices / infra (add)

Item	Spec / note
Always-on collection hosts	Small VPS fleet preferred over home lab (home IP = attribution + uptime tax)
Object storage or dedicated backup box	Archive durability; versioned
Monitoring for collectors	Uptime + “last successful run” alerts to you
Residential / mobile proxy pool (paid)	When targets or platforms demand non-DC egress — document legality per use
Optional: colocation / mini-PC in a site you control	Only if you understand the attribution story

Software / platforms (add)

Item	Purpose
Schedulers	cron / systemd timers / GitHub Actions self-hosted / Prefect-class — pick one and standardize
Datastore	Postgres + object store, or equivalent; history tables , not overwrite
Alerting	Change detect on domains, certs, selected social surfaces, watchlists
Passive DNS / CT monitoring	Continuous, not one-shot
Optional: OpenCTI or MISP	Only if you will spend 1–4 h/week keeping it honest; else wire feeds into what you already run
Optional: commercial SOCMINT (ShadowDragon, Social Links, Skopenow, Babel Street, ...)	Expensive; vendor dependency; Tier 3+ budget

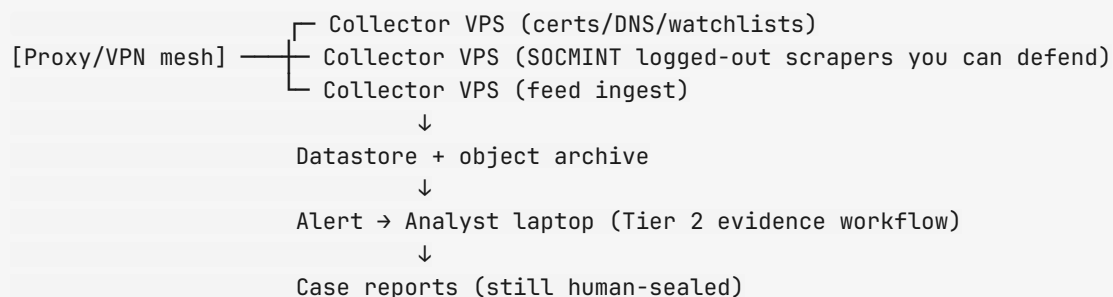
CTI feed kit (small shop)

Wire 2–3 high-signal free feeds before buying a TIP: abuse.ch (URLhaus, MalwareBazaar, ThreatFox), CISA KEV; then OTX/Spamhaus/CIRCL as needed.

Phone / laptop changes at Tier 3

- Phone stays a field/2FA/capture device — **collectors do not run on phones**
- Primary laptop becomes an **admin terminal** for the fleet more than a collector
- MFA hardware keys everywhere; no SMS MFA on infra

Desk / architecture look at Tier 3



Ops habits that are now part of the kit

- Runbook per collector; who restarts it; how to detect silent failure
- Backup restore tested quarterly
- Written retention/deletion on the archive
- Footing tag on every collector (A vs B)

Explicitly not required yet

Named QA role, accreditation, enterprise Chainalysis/TRM seats, 24/7 shift roster.

Tier 4 — Team

Capability: Parallel casework, specialization, review. Governance becomes the product.

Cost: Headcount-dominated; tooling is a rounding error.

What actually changes: Access control, audit logs, retention, legal review, written tradecraft standard, second reader before anything leaves.

Devices / identity (add)

Item	Spec / note
Standard analyst build image	Same VM/golden image for every hire
Central image management	Packer/Ansible/MDM — reproducible environments
Hardware token MFA on everything	No exceptions for “just Slack”
Separate roles’ access	Collectors ≠ analysts ≠ admin break-glass
Shared evidence locker with ACLs	Not a shared Google Drive free-for-all

Apps / collaboration (add)

Item	Purpose
Case management that supports roles	Even if it’s still Obsidian + git + review PR discipline at small scale
Ticketing	Jira/Linear/etc. — engagement → question → done
Comms	Tiered: open ops chat vs case-restricted channels
Secrets manager	Team vault; no secrets in Discord
Code/config repo for collectors	Review required to change a scraper

Process artifacts that count as “kit”

- Written tradecraft manual (the doc becomes a manual, not notes)
- Confidence standard + report template enforced
- Second-reader checklist
- Named counsel / legal escalation path
- Engagement acceptance & decline criteria
- Onboarding kit clone of Tier 2 desk in under one week

Desk look at Tier 4

```
Analyst A ┌
Analyst B ┤ SSO / MDM / golden image — Case ACLs — Evidence locker
Collect Eng└
           ┌ QA / review gate
           └ Legal on-call path
Infra runs Tier 3 fleet with on-call rotation (even if small)
```

Tier 5 — Institutional

Capability: Platform-class tooling, licensed commercial feeds, formal standards, accreditation, work that requires them (gov, regulated finance, litigation support).

Reality: Procurement and compliance posture as much as tech. Many enterprise forensic/intel platforms **are not sold to individuals**.

What appears in the kit (examples — vendor landscape moves)

Lane	Institutional-class examples
On-chain	Chainalysis, TRM Labs, Elliptic, Crystal
SOCMINT / fused intel	Babel Street, ShadowDragon enterprise, equivalent
Forensic platforms	EnCase/Magnet/Cellebrite-class where DFIR is in-scope (Footing B / lawful possession)
TIP / fusion	Enterprise OpenCTI/MISP deployments, commercial TIPs
Accreditation	GIAC/GOSI as ticket items; org policies, audits, clearances as required
Facilities	Badge access, visitor rules, classified/controlled handling if applicable

What “setup looks like”

Less like a hacker desk, more like: controlled endpoints, DLP, audit, vendor contracts, DPIA/legitimate-interest records, retention legal holds, insurer questionnaires answered with evidence.

Branch add-ons (bolt onto the core tier)

Buy these only when that branch is in your active build order (see Capability Tree §8).

OSINT / infra (A)

Already in core Tier 1–2. Depth: OSINT Capability Ladder §4.

SOCMINT (A default; D if you engage)

Tier	Add
1	Logged-out browser discipline; archive-before-cite; toolkit bookmarks
2	Research identities + antideetect if required ; Hunchly on social captures
3+	Commercial SOCMINT platform or defended custom collectors

GEOINT / imagery (A)

Tier	Add
1	InVID/WeVerify, ExifTool, Google Earth Pro, Sentinel Hub / OSM, Bellingcat toolkit
2	Offline map packs on research phone; structured geolocation notes (cues → candidate → confirm)
3	Watchlists on areas/sensors you actually revisit

FININT / on-chain (A public layer)

Tier	Add
1	Explorers + Breadcrumbs/MetaSleuth/Arkham free; label timestamp discipline
2	Maltego crypto entities; graph exports into case file
5	Chainalysis/TRM/Elliptic-class

CORPINT (A)

Tier	Add
1	Register bookmarks per jurisdiction you touch; OpenCorporates-class; PDF account dumps into vault
2	Paid credits for stubborn jurisdictions; officer graph in Maltego/Obsidian

Breach exposure (A — query only)

Tier	Add
1	HIBP / reputable broker queries
2	Written rule: never attempt login with recovered credentials

CTI / CYBINT passive (A)

Tier	Add
1–2	abuse.ch + KEV + VT/urlscan as needed
3	TIP only with a maintainer

ASM / authorized recon (Footing B)

Tier	Add
B-kit	Written RoE + scope file; naabu / nuke1 / Burp/etc. allowed only in-scope; separate “authorized” browser/VM profile; engagement letter in the case root

DFIR (Footing B — lawful possession)

Tier	Add
B-kit	Write blockers, imaging tools, volatility order cheatsheet, evidence bags/labels, isolated analysis VM (Tsurugi-class), counsel on seizure/privacy

SIGINT / HUMINT / TECHINT intercept & contact

Not stocked in this kit. Different legal footing (C/D). No phone-app list here on purpose.

One-page shopping lists

Buy / set up for Tier 1

1. Dedicated research computer + FDE + 32–64 GB RAM + NVMe
2. Trace Labs OSINT VM (or roll-your-own) + snapshot habit
3. VPN (paid) + Obsidian + Bitwarden/KeePassXC research vault
4. Firefox containers / separate profiles
5. ExifTool, InVID, passive CLI recon tools
6. Research email + free scan-platform accounts
7. Optional: cheap research phone + prepaid SIM + TOTP app

Upgrade package for Tier 2

1. Hunchly
2. Encrypted evidence SSD + retention policy written
3. Second attribution machine or strict antideetect profiles
4. Physical burner SIM discipline
5. Case folder template + source log + graded report template
6. First paid scan membership (often Shodan)
7. Maltego/SpiderFoot workflow you can repeat

Upgrade package for Tier 3

1. VPS fleet + object storage + scheduler
2. Change-alerting on your real watchlists
3. Proxy strategy documented
4. Backup/restore drill
5. Feed ingest; TIP only if staffed

Upgrade package for Tier 4

1. Golden analyst image + MDM/SSO
2. ACL'd evidence locker + audit logging
3. Second-reader gate + tradecraft manual
4. On-call for collectors
5. Named legal path

Tier 5

Procurement, accreditations, enterprise contracts — not a shopping cart.

AI layer (any tier — bolt-on rules)

Do	Don't
Use LLMs to structure tool output, draft timelines, suggest pivots	Let model output enter a report unverified
Sandbox tool execution (containers, timeouts, rate limits)	Give an agent untrusted page content and consequential actions in one loop
Treat output as junior-analyst first draft	Autonomously run active scanners

Relationship table

Concern	Document
Branch map & legal footings	<i>Intelligence Capability Tree</i>
OSINT tier philosophy & deep tool/legal notes	<i>OSINT Capability Ladder</i>
What to own/run at each tier (this file)	<i>Intelligence Capability Kit</i>
SIGINT / HUMINT / exploit inventories	Counsel-backed docs only

Changelog

Version	Date	Changes
1.0	Aug 2026	Initial full Tier 0–5 kits: devices, phone apps, software, accounts, desk diagrams, branch add-ons, shopping lists